

**STATE OF MINNESOTA
SEVENTH JUDICIAL DISTRICT COURT
JUVENILE / CHILD PROTECTION DIVISION**

In the Matter of the Welfare of the Children of James Chapman,
Court File No.: 80-JV-26-492

**SUPPLEMENTAL CONSTITUTIONAL MEMORANDUM IN SUPPORT OF PENDING MOTIONS,
INCLUDING PARENT'S MOTION TO DISMISS OR STAY AND RESTORATION OF PARENTAL
RIGHTS**

Submitted Pro Se by James Chapman, Respondent Father

STATEMENT REGARDING THIS FILING

This memorandum supplements, and does not replace, any previously filed Motion to Dismiss or Stay, Supplemental Motion, Motion to Preserve Evidence, Ex Parte Motion, or any other pending filing in this matter. It is submitted solely to update the Court regarding procedural developments occurring after those filings, to set forth in full the constitutional arguments previously raised, and to ensure a complete record.

After the filing of the pending Ex Parte Motion, Respondent was electronically served by the County. The Court has not yet ruled on the Ex Parte Motion. This subsequent service does not withdraw, replace, or waive any argument previously presented. Rather, it establishes an additional procedural fact for the Court's consideration.

Respondent respectfully requests that this memorandum be read together with all prior filings and not in lieu of them. The constitutional arguments set forth below are presented without substantive change from Respondent's previously prepared memorandum.

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PRELIMINARY STATEMENT

This memorandum supplements, and does not replace, the constitutional and procedural arguments already raised in my pending Motion to Dismiss or Stay and related filings in this matter. Its purpose is to set forth, in the structured form that appellate review requires, the constitutional mechanism by which the State's conduct in this proceeding has violated my rights and the rights of my children as members of a family unit protected by the Fourteenth Amendment.

A recurring feature of child-protection litigation is that the underlying constitutional violation is often described only in the language of grievance — that the process was unfair, that the removal was premature, that the parent was not heard. Those descriptions are accurate, but they do not, standing alone, identify the constitutional doctrine that has been violated. This memorandum identifies that doctrine. It demonstrates that the State has employed a civil child-protection mechanism to accomplish, in substance, what the Constitution permits it to accomplish only through the criminal process and its accompanying safeguards — and that it has done so by inverting the sequence that due process requires, shifting the burden of proof onto the parent, and then treating the consequences of its own premature action as evidence justifying the action's continuation.

This memorandum is organized around eleven constitutional propositions, followed by an application of those propositions to the specific facts of this case, and a statement of the relief requested.

I. THE CONSTITUTIONAL STATUS OF PARENTAL RIGHTS

The right of a parent to the care, custody, and control of his or her children is among the oldest of the fundamental liberty interests recognized by the United States Supreme Court. See *Troxel v. Granville*, 530 U.S. 57, 65 (2000) (plurality opinion) (“The liberty interest at issue in this case — the interest of parents in the care, custody, and control of their children — is perhaps the oldest of the fundamental liberty interests recognized by this Court.”); *Santosky v. Kramer*, 455 U.S. 745, 753 (1982) (recognizing that a parent's interest in the accuracy and justice of a decision to terminate parental rights is a “commanding” one); *Stanley v. Illinois*, 405 U.S. 645, 651 (1972) (“The rights to conceive and to raise one's children have been deemed ‘essential,’ ‘basic civil rights of man,’ and ‘[r]ights far more precious . . . than property rights.’”).

Because this interest is fundamental, governmental interference with it is subject to heightened constitutional scrutiny. This is not a matter of degree; it is a matter of category. Ordinary governmental regulation of conduct is tested against minimal rationality. Governmental interference with a fundamental right is tested against a substantially more demanding standard, and it is the State — not the individual whose rights are at stake — that bears the burden of justifying the interference. Minnesota law is in accord: where a fundamental right is implicated, the burden of justifying State intrusion rests upon the State, not upon the parent who must otherwise defend a right that the Constitution already guarantees him.

This foundational principle governs every subsequent argument in this memorandum. Each of the constitutional defects identified below — premature removal, burden-shifting, manufactured best-interests findings, vague standards, and the loss of objective evidence — is a defect precisely because it treats a fundamental right as though it were a conditional privilege, to be restored only if the parent can affirmatively demonstrate his fitness, rather than a right that the State must justify infringing in the first instance.

II. THE STATE MAY NOT ACCOMPLISH INDIRECTLY WHAT THE CONSTITUTION FORBIDS IT FROM ACCOMPLISHING DIRECTLY

One of the oldest principles of American constitutional law is that the government may not accomplish indirectly what it is forbidden from accomplishing directly. A constitutional guarantee cannot be circumvented merely by relabeling the proceeding in which the government seeks to achieve the same practical result.

Where the factual theory advanced by the State is that a parent has engaged in conduct sufficiently serious to justify the immediate removal of his children from his custody, the practical consequences that follow closely resemble those that follow a criminal conviction: separation from one's children, restriction of physical liberty and movement, mandatory compliance with governmental directives as a condition of any future restoration of rights, and substantial and lasting reputational injury within the parent's community.

Despite this functional equivalence, the State did not proceed through the criminal justice system, with its accompanying safeguards of probable cause, the right of confrontation, compulsory process, the presumption of innocence, and, where applicable, proof beyond a reasonable doubt. Instead, the State proceeded through a civil child-protection mechanism that produces substantially the same practical consequences while affording substantially reduced procedural protection.

The Constitution does not permit the government to evade its own guarantees by changing the caption on the case. A reviewing court must therefore examine the substance of what occurred — the practical deprivation actually imposed upon the parent and the family — rather than resting upon the procedural label attached to the proceeding that produced it. Where a civil proceeding is used as a functional substitute for a criminal prosecution, without affording the safeguards that a criminal prosecution would require, the proceeding does not escape constitutional scrutiny merely because it is styled as civil rather than criminal.

III. EMERGENCY POWERS ARE NARROW EXCEPTIONS, NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR CONSTITUTIONAL PROCESS

Emergency child-protection authority exists to address genuinely immediate dangers to a child's safety — circumstances in which the delay inherent in ordinary process would itself create an unacceptable risk of harm. It is, by its nature, an exception to the ordinary constitutional requirement that process precede deprivation, and like all such exceptions it must be construed narrowly and applied only where its underlying justification — genuine, immediate necessity — is actually present.

Where the State possesses evidence that a parent has engaged in conduct serious enough to justify removing children from that parent's custody, and where no genuine emergency requiring instantaneous action exists, the ordinary avenues available to the State — including the criminal justice system, with its accompanying constitutional safeguards — remain available and adequate. The emergency exception is not a general-purpose alternative to be invoked whenever it is more convenient than the ordinary process; it is a narrow accommodation for the rare case in which ordinary process cannot be observed without unacceptable risk.

In practice, however, emergency child-protection authority is frequently invoked well beyond the narrow circumstances that justify it, and is then permitted to persist — through successive short-term orders — long after any genuine emergency has passed. The result is that an exception designed for the rare case of true necessity becomes, in practice, the ordinary mechanism by which parental rights are restricted, without the parent ever having received the process that would have been due had the matter proceeded through ordinary channels. Once invoked, the label “emergency” does not itself justify the continued suspension of fundamental rights; the State must be able to point to a continuing emergency, not merely to the fact that one was once declared.

III.A. Allegations of Immediate Child Endangerment Require Careful Constitutional Scrutiny

The State's justification for emergency removal necessarily rests upon the assertion that a child faces an immediate and serious danger requiring governmental intervention before the ordinary protections of due process can be afforded. Emergency authority exists only because the law recognizes that, in truly extraordinary circumstances, delay itself may expose a child to imminent harm.

Minnesota law separately criminalizes child neglect and endangerment. See Minn. Stat. § 609.378 (Neglect or Endangerment of a Child). Where the facts genuinely establish conduct that places a child in immediate danger within the meaning of that statute, those same facts may also provide a basis for criminal investigation and, where supported by probable cause — a standard considerably less demanding than the showings ordinarily required to justify the continued restriction of a fundamental right in a civil proceeding — criminal prosecution. Criminal proceedings exist precisely because allegations of that seriousness implicate both the protection of children and the constitutional rights of the accused.

This Court need not conclude that every child-protection matter requires a parallel criminal prosecution. It plainly does not. The purposes of criminal law and child-protection law are distinct, and prosecutors decline charges for many legitimate reasons unrelated to the underlying facts — evidentiary sufficiency, witness availability, and the exercise of ordinary prosecutorial discretion among them. The absence of criminal charges is accordingly not, standing alone, proof that no danger existed, and this memorandum does not ask the Court to treat it as such.

The absence of criminal charges is, however, relevant — not as an admission, but as one circumstance the Court may weigh — where the State simultaneously maintains that circumstances were so immediate and so grave that they justified dispensing with the ordinary sequence of notice, hearing, and judicial review before interfering with one of the oldest fundamental liberty interests recognized by the Constitution. If the alleged danger was sufficiently immediate to justify emergency removal without prior process, the State should be prepared to identify objective, articulable facts demonstrating that immediate danger. If, by contrast, the available evidence does not establish probable cause even to investigate or prosecute criminal child endangerment under a standard lower than the one the State now asks this Court to accept in a civil proceeding, the Court may properly ask whether the asserted emergency was truly so immediate that constitutional process could not reasonably have preceded the deprivation.

This is not an argument that criminal prosecution is a prerequisite to child-protection proceedings. Rather, it is an argument that the constitutional justification for bypassing ordinary due process must be measured against the objective seriousness of the alleged conduct. Emergency powers are justified by genuine necessity, not by conclusory assertions of danger. The constitutional concern arises when emergency child-protection procedures become a substitute for the procedural safeguards that ordinarily accompany governmental action based upon allegations of serious misconduct. The State may not rely upon the label “emergency” alone; it must demonstrate, through specific and objectively verifiable facts, that the circumstances truly required immediate action before constitutionally adequate process could be provided.

Where the record instead reflects disputed allegations, available objective evidence, no meaningful notice, and no opportunity to be heard before the deprivation occurred, the Court should carefully examine whether the emergency exception was properly invoked at all. Because emergency authority is an exception to due process — not a replacement for it — the State bears the burden of demonstrating that the exception was both necessary and constitutionally justified.

This structural point may be stated as a single governing principle, a constitutional asymmetry that the State cannot avoid in either direction. If the allegations against a parent are minor, they cannot support the immediate and severe danger that emergency removal requires. If the allegations are major — serious enough to justify bypassing notice, hearing, and judicial review before deprivation — then they are serious enough to warrant the objective evidentiary scrutiny that the law ordinarily demands of allegations of that gravity, including the comparatively modest probable-cause threshold that governs a criminal investigation. What the State may not do is treat the allegations as major for

purposes of justifying an emergency bypass of due process, while treating them as unworthy of the objective scrutiny — criminal or otherwise — that allegations of that seriousness would ordinarily receive. The State's burden to justify the emergency exception to due process is not satisfied by vague accusations calibrated to permit both outcomes at once.

IV. DUE PROCESS MUST PRECEDE DEPRIVATION

The more fundamental the constitutional right at stake, the greater the procedural protection that must precede its deprivation. This principle is not merely a general maxim; it is the specific holding of a substantial body of federal and Minnesota constitutional law governing the timing of governmental action against fundamental interests.

Yet child-protection proceedings frequently operate in the reverse sequence. The constitutionally required order is: (1) investigation; (2) notice; (3) an opportunity to be heard; (4) a judicial determination based upon legally sufficient evidence; and (5) only then, if constitutionally justified, interference with fundamental parental rights. In this case, and in cases like it, the sequence instead becomes: (1) removal and restriction; (2) separation of parent and child; (3) hearings conducted without meaningful advance notice; and (4) a proceeding in which the parent is effectively required to demonstrate why rights already taken should be restored.

That inversion is not a mere procedural irregularity. It is the precise constitutional harm that the due process requirement of pre-deprivation process exists to prevent. A hearing that follows the deprivation it is meant to justify does not serve the same constitutional function as a hearing that precedes it, because the practical, psychological, and relational harm of separation has already occurred and cannot be undone by a later favorable ruling. Where practicable, due process is not satisfied by any hearing — it requires the right hearing, held at the right time, which is to say, before the deprivation occurs, except in the narrow circumstances addressed in Section III and Section III.A above.

V. THE PROCEEDINGS IMPROPERLY SHIFTED THE CONSTITUTIONAL BURDEN

The Constitution places the burden of justification upon the State whenever it seeks to interfere with a fundamental liberty interest. That burden exists before the right is taken. It does not arise afterward, and it is not satisfied by requiring the individual whose right has already been taken to demonstrate why it should be given back.

In this case, the practical burden was reversed. My parental rights were restricted first. My children were separated from me first. Only afterward was I required to attempt to prove why the State should return rights that, under the Constitution, should never have been removed without the State first satisfying its own burden of justification. The Constitution presumes liberty; it does not presume restriction and require the individual to overcome that presumption.

This burden-shift is not merely unfair as a matter of practical fairness — it is a distinct constitutional violation in its own right, independent of any factual dispute about the underlying allegations. Even if the underlying allegations were ultimately proven true, a process that restricts fundamental rights first and requires the parent to justify their restoration afterward has already violated due process by the time any such proof is offered, because the constitutional guarantee is a guarantee of process before deprivation, not merely a guarantee of an eventual correct outcome.

VI. STRUCTURAL BIAS CREATED BY INFORMATION ASYMMETRY

The State necessarily possesses substantially greater access to information than an individual parent involved in a child-protection proceeding. Agency personnel create the reports upon which the court relies. Agency personnel select what information from their investigation is included in those reports, and what is omitted. Agency personnel characterize which statements they regard as credible and which they do not. In many cases, agency personnel communicate extensively with one parent while the other parent has little or no meaningful opportunity to respond before emergency decisions are made.

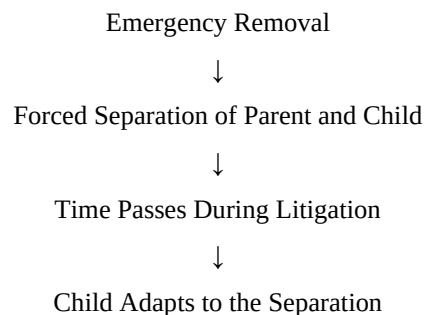
Once judicial proceedings begin, courts understandably afford significant weight to agency reports, on the assumption that they were prepared by neutral governmental actors acting in the child's interest. That assumption, while generally reasonable, does not relieve a reviewing court of its independent obligation to test the reliability of those reports through adversarial process before relying upon them to justify continued interference with a fundamental right. When agency reports omit exculpatory information, fail to include contrary evidence that was available to the agency, or present disputed and contested facts as though they were established and uncontested, the resulting process becomes structurally one-sided — not necessarily because any individual acted in bad faith, but because the structure of the process itself concentrates informational control in the hands of one party to a dispute in which fundamental rights are at stake.

The constitutional solution to this structural imbalance is not blind distrust of child-protection agencies, whose personnel in most cases act in good faith and in the sincere belief that they are protecting children. The constitutional solution is complete transparency, the preservation and disclosure of objective evidence, and meaningful adversarial testing of agency conclusions before those conclusions are permitted to justify continued restriction of a fundamental right.

VII. THE STATE CANNOT MANUFACTURE THE “BEST INTERESTS” ANALYSIS IT LATER RELIES UPON

Perhaps the most structurally troubling feature of contemporary child-protection practice is the self-reinforcing sequence by which a temporary, emergency separation is permitted to become the very evidentiary foundation for its own permanence.

The sequence proceeds as follows. The State first creates a separation between parent and child, ordinarily through an emergency removal. Time then passes while the proceeding is litigated. During that time, the child necessarily adapts to the new arrangement, because children are resilient and because the passage of time itself produces adaptation regardless of the underlying merits of the original removal. The State, or the guardian ad litem, then observes that the child has adapted to the new arrangement, and argues that the child's best interests are served by maintaining stability — that is, by preserving the very arrangement that the State's own temporary action created. The temporary order, justified initially as an emergency measure, is thereby transformed into a permanent one, not because the original allegations were ever fully tested through adversarial process, but because the passage of time during litigation generated its own justification for continuing the separation.



↓
State Argues: “Best Interests Require Maintaining Stability”

↓
Temporary Order Becomes Permanent Order

This is a constitutional feedback loop, not a neutral application of a best-interests standard. It permits the State to generate, through its own initial and unreviewed action, the very facts that are later offered to justify that action's permanence. A best-interests analysis that rests upon conditions created by the State's own premature intervention is not an independent evaluation of the child's welfare; it is a bootstrap that converts an unproven allegation into a permanent outcome through the passage of time alone.

This does not mean that stability and continuity of care are illegitimate considerations in a best-interests analysis; they are well-established and important ones. It means that where the instability being remedied by “maintaining the status quo” was itself created by unreviewed State action, the State should not be permitted to rely upon that self-created instability as though it were an independent, neutral fact about the child's circumstances. A reviewing court applying a best-interests standard in these circumstances must distinguish between stability that arose from a fair and constitutionally adequate process and stability that arose from the State's own premature and unreviewed intervention.

VIII. THE STATE AS SUBSTITUTE LITIGANT

A related and underexamined structural problem arises when a governmental child-protection agency, in substance, adopts the litigation position of one parent in a custody or family dispute before that position has been adversarially tested.

When a governmental agency adopts one parent's narrative before adversarial testing occurs, and then exercises sovereign authority to impose restrictions that a private litigant could not obtain without an independent judicial finding, the agency risks transforming itself from a neutral investigator into a substitute litigant — effectively deploying the State's coercive authority on behalf of one private party's position in what is, at its core, a dispute between two parents. Due process requires governmental neutrality in this context. It does not permit the sovereign to become, in substance, an advocate for one side of a private dispute before constitutional procedures have been satisfied and before an independent judicial finding has been made.

This argument is directed at the structure of the process, not at the motives of any individual caseworker or agency employee, the overwhelming majority of whom act in good faith. Structural arguments of this kind are, for that reason, more appropriately addressed by a reviewing court than arguments sounding in individual misconduct, because they identify a defect in the process itself — one that would produce the same constitutional harm regardless of the good faith of the individuals administering it, and one that accordingly calls for a structural, procedural remedy rather than a finding of fault against any particular person.

IX. VAGUE STANDARDS CANNOT REPLACE OBJECTIVE CONSTITUTIONAL STANDARDS

Many child-protection determinations rely upon broad and inherently elastic terms such as “endangerment,” “risk,” or “best interests.” These concepts serve legitimate and necessary purposes; no statutory scheme could anticipate every configuration of facts relevant to a child's welfare, and some degree of evaluative judgment is unavoidable in this area of the law.

Constitutional due process nonetheless requires that governmental standards be sufficiently definite to provide fair notice of what is required and to prevent arbitrary or inconsistent enforcement. Where a standard becomes so dependent upon subjective interpretation that different officials, presented with the same evidence, may reach dramatically different conclusions, the standard no longer performs the constitutional function that definiteness is meant to serve. This concern is especially acute where the governmental action in question involves the temporary or permanent separation of parents from their children, because the consequences of inconsistent or arbitrary application fall not upon an abstract regulatory interest but upon the family relationship itself.

Fundamental constitutional rights cannot be made to depend solely upon shifting administrative interpretation of an undefined standard, applied by different officials at different times without any objective anchor. Where vague standards are used to justify the restriction of a fundamental right, a reviewing court should require that the specific facts said to satisfy the standard be identified with particularity, and should not treat the invocation of a general term such as “risk” or “endangerment,” standing alone and unconnected to specific, objectively verifiable facts, as sufficient justification for continued interference with the parent-child relationship.

X. THE FAILURE TO PRESERVE OBJECTIVE EVIDENCE INCREASES THE RISK OF CONSTITUTIONAL ERROR

Modern technology allows most interactions relevant to a child-protection investigation — interviews, home visits, and other material encounters between agency personnel and family members — to be recorded accurately and completely. Where fundamental constitutional rights are at stake, complete and objective recordings of investigatory interactions protect every participant in the process: they protect children, whose statements are preserved in their original context rather than filtered through a summary; they protect parents, who are given a fair opportunity to contest characterizations of what occurred; they protect investigators, whose good-faith conduct is documented rather than left to reconstruction from memory; and they protect the courts, which are thereby able to base their decisions upon complete evidence rather than upon summaries prepared by a single interested party to the proceeding.

Objective recordings reduce disputes over credibility, preserve the context in which statements were made, and allow judicial decisions to rest upon the full record of what occurred rather than upon after-the-fact characterizations. Where such objective evidence exists but is not preserved, or is preserved but not disclosed, the resulting record is necessarily less reliable than it could and should have been, and the risk of constitutional error — the risk that a fundamental right will be restricted based upon an incomplete or inaccurate account of what actually occurred — is correspondingly and unnecessarily increased.

This is not a criticism of any particular agency practice in the abstract. It is an observation that where the government seeks to justify interference with a fundamental right, and where objective evidence bearing directly upon the factual basis for that interference exists or could readily have been created, the absence of that evidence from the record should weigh against, not in favor of, the sufficiency of the showing the State has made.

XI. APPLICATION OF THESE PRINCIPLES TO THIS CASE

The foregoing constitutional principles are not abstract. They describe, precisely, the sequence of events that occurred in this matter.

A. Absence of Meaningful Notice

I was not afforded meaningful notice before the removal in this case occurred. To the contrary, I was specifically informed, before the events giving rise to this proceeding, that such action would not occur. That representation was material to my decision to leave the circumstances I was in at the time. Had I been informed that removal was in fact imminent, I would not have left. This is a factual dispute capable of objective verification, and it lies at the heart of the notice defect described in Section IV above.

B. Available Objective Evidence

This factual dispute is not one that must be resolved by assumption or by resort to competing characterizations alone. Objective evidence bearing directly upon it exists and, where preserved, is capable of resolving it. That evidence includes, without limitation:

- contemporaneous written communications;
- text messages exchanged at or near the relevant time;
- agency records, including intake and investigatory notes;
- law-enforcement records, including any record of whether the allegations were referred for criminal investigation under Minn. Stat. § 609.378;
- body-camera recordings, where such recordings were made;
- agency recordings of interviews or interactions with the family;
- witness testimony from individuals present during the relevant events;
- testimony from my children, subject to appropriate protective procedures; and
- testimony from other individuals with direct knowledge of the relevant events.

The existence of this category of objective evidence matters because due process requires that genuine factual disputes be resolved through evidence, tested through adversarial process, and not through assumption or through deference to whichever account was reduced to writing first. Where such evidence exists, it should be preserved, disclosed, and considered before any final determination is made regarding the restriction or restoration of my parental rights.

C. Illustration of the Burden-Shift and the Manufactured Best-Interests Problem

The sequence described in Sections V and VII above is not hypothetical in this case. My rights were restricted before any adversarial testing of the underlying allegations occurred. Time has since passed. To the extent that any subsequent proceeding relies upon the resulting passage of time, or upon my children's adaptation to a separation that the State's own premature action created, as evidence supporting continued separation, that reliance would repeat — rather than cure — the constitutional defect identified in Section VII. A best-interests determination in this matter should be made upon an independent evaluation of my fitness as a parent and the actual, objectively established facts, not upon the self-generated consequences of the State's own initial and unreviewed action.

D. The Asserted Emergency Has Not Been Tested Against the Scrutiny Section III.A Requires

The constitutional asymmetry described in Section III.A above applies directly to this case. To the extent the State has characterized the underlying allegations as sufficiently serious to justify emergency removal without prior process, the objective, articulable facts supporting that characterization — and the extent to which those facts were, or were not, referred for criminal investigation or prosecution under Minn. Stat. § 609.378 — have not been tested through adversarial process. The Court should require that showing before treating the emergency justification as established.

XII. REQUESTED RELIEF

For the reasons set forth above and in my previously filed Motion to Dismiss or Stay and accompanying submissions, I respectfully request that this Court:

- Dismiss or stay the proceedings to the extent they rest upon findings or restrictions imposed without the constitutionally required pre-deprivation process described in Section IV;
- Require the State to identify the objective, articulable facts supporting its emergency justification, consistent with Section III.A, including whether the alleged conduct was referred for criminal investigation or prosecution under Minn. Stat. § 609.378;
- Order the preservation and disclosure of all objective evidence identified in Section XI(B), including agency records, recordings, and communications bearing upon the notice and removal issues raised in this memorandum;
- Hold an evidentiary hearing, with the burden of proof properly placed upon the State as required by Section V, at which the underlying factual allegations may be tested through adversarial process before any further restriction of my parental rights is continued;
- Decline to treat the passage of time or my children's adaptation to a State-created separation as independent evidence supporting continued separation, consistent with Section VII;
- Restore my parental rights and contact with my children to the fullest extent consistent with their safety, pending the constitutionally adequate process described above; and
- Grant such other and further relief as the Court deems just and equitable.

XIII. CONCLUSION

This case is not merely about disputed factual allegations. It concerns whether the constitutional protections guaranteed before the government interferes with one of the most fundamental liberty interests recognized by American law were actually provided in this proceeding.

The Constitution does not permit the State to take first and justify later. It does not permit the burden of proof to shift onto a parent to establish his own fitness only after his rights have already been restricted. It does not permit the State to rely, as evidence of a child's best interests, upon conditions that the State's own unreviewed action created. It does not permit the State to treat allegations as grave enough to justify bypassing due process while treating those same allegations as unworthy of the objective scrutiny that allegations of that gravity would ordinarily receive. And it does not permit procedural shortcuts simply because a proceeding is labeled civil rather than criminal, where the practical consequences to the family are functionally indistinguishable from those that would follow a criminal conviction.

The constitutional guarantees of due process, equal protection, and the protection afforded to fundamental parental rights remain fully applicable whenever the State seeks to interfere with the parent-child relationship. For the reasons set forth in my motions and in this supplemental memorandum, I respectfully submit that the proceedings in this matter failed to satisfy those constitutional requirements, and that the relief requested above should be granted.

Respectfully submitted,

James Chapman

Respondent Father, Pro Se

xhecarpenxer@gmail.com

(Electronically signed and filed)